expression: the cult of the Mother Goddess, known in the South as Amman (Mother) or Aatha (Mother), Mariamman (Mother Mari), or simply Mari, which means ‘rain’. Mariamman’s prime attribute is as the bringer of rain and, by extension, fertility. She is also the goddess who wards off all the so-called ‘heat diseases’ such as rashes and smallpox, and she has her fierce aspect, in which capacity she is worshipped as Angala-amman, the ‘Mother Protector’, a fearful apparition with wild, unkempt hair and blood dripping from extended fangs who guards the village from ghosts and demons and accepts blood sacrifices.

Northern India has comparatively few shrines devoted exclusively to the Mother Goddess, chiefly because she has been more thoroughly absorbed into the person of Shiva’s *shakti*, his consort in the form of Durga Mata or Kali. In the South shrines of the Mother Goddess are seen in virtually every village, often sited close to one or more anthills, the favourite haunt of cobras. Here the goddess is found in her most basic forms, often as no more than an approximation of the female form modelled out of sand and clay or even as a slab of granite with a sharp tip at the top not unlike a spear-head, frequently seen garlanded with flowers. One such Amman shrine is the Angala Parameshwari temple at Putlur, now swallowed up in the north-western suburbs of Chennai, where the goddess takes the frankly unprepossessing form of a large anthill supposedly resembling a pregnant woman sleeping with her mouth wide open. Hence the name of the village, Putlur, from the Tamil word *putru*, ‘snake hole’.